

Chapter Three: Dress Like You Already Have the Job.

On Monday morning, I woke up before my alarm.

For several seconds, I lay still and stared at the ceiling.

Then I remembered the interview.

My stomach tightened immediately.

Beside me, Mia was still asleep with half the blanket wrapped around her legs.

“Mia,” I whispered.

She did not move.

“Mia,” I repeated, louder this time.

Mia opened one eye.

“What happened?” she asked.

“My interview is today.”

“I know.”

“You said you would wake up early.”

“I am awake.”

“You opened one eye.”

“The other one is preparing.”

I sat up and checked the time.

It was six seventeen.

My interview was at ten.

The office was almost an hour away, depending on traffic, rain, public transport, road construction, and whether the universe had decided to embarrass me personally.

I got out of bed.

“I need to leave by eight,” I said.

Mia pulled the blanket over her head.

“Then why are we awake at six?”

“Because I need time to get ready.”

“You are applying for a job, Ana. You are not preparing for surgery.”

“I need to shower, fix my hair, choose an outfit, print another copy of my CV, and practise my answers.”

Mia lowered the blanket.

“You printed five copies yesterday.”

“What if they ask for six?”

“Then the company has poor planning.”

I walked toward the wardrobe.

“I’m serious.”

“So am I,” Mia replied. “If six people need your CV and nobody owns a printer, you do not want to work there.”

I opened the wardrobe doors and stared at my clothes.

I owned several dresses, three pairs of black trousers, two office blouses, and one blazer that had not fitted me properly since my cousin’s wedding.

None of them looked like something a successful communications professional would wear.

They looked like the clothes of a woman who had received an invitation three days ago and was trying not to panic.

Mia got out of bed and joined me.

“Wear the blue dress,” she suggested.

“The blue dress is too tight.”

“It is fitted.”

“It prevents deep breathing.”

“You should not be breathing deeply during an interview. It looks emotional.”

I pulled out a white blouse.

“What about this?”

Mia touched the sleeve.

“There is a stain.”

I examined it.

“That is not a stain. It is part of the fabric.”

“It is brown.”

“It is cream.”

“It is concentrated cream.”

I put the blouse back.

“What about black trousers and the pink blouse?” I asked.

“The pink blouse makes you look friendly.”

“That is good.”

“Too friendly.”

“What does that mean?”

“It says you will stay late without being paid.”

I looked at her. “Clothes cannot say that.”

“That blouse can.”

I pulled out a dark green blouse.

Mia shook her head before I could speak.

“No.”

“Why?”

“You wore that when your ex broke up with you.”

“That was six years ago.”

“The blouse remembers.”

“The blouse is fabric.”

“Fabric carries energy.”

“You watched one spiritual video last week.”

“And now I understand textiles.”

I sat on the edge of the bed.

“I have nothing to wear.”

Mia crossed her arms.

“You have many things to wear. You simply do not like any of them.”

“That is the same problem.”

“It is not.”

My phone began to ring.

Mama’s name appeared on the screen.

I answered.

“Good morning, Mama,” I said.

“Are you awake?” Mama asked.

“Yes.”

“Did you eat?”

“Not yet.”

“You should eat.”

“I will.”

“Do not drink too much coffee.”

“I know.”

“And bring water.”

“Mama, I know.”

“Where is Mia?”

I looked toward Mia.

She was holding the blue dress against herself in front of the mirror.

“She’s here,” I replied.

“Is she going with you?” Mama asked.

“No. Why would she come to my interview?”

“For support.”

“She can support me from home.”

Mia looked at me through the mirror.

“I was planning to come,” she said.

I covered the phone.

“No, you were not.”

“Yes, I was.”

“You cannot sit inside the interview room.”

“I can wait outside.”

Mama became quiet.

“Ana,” Mama said, “who are you talking to?”

“Mia.”

“Put her on the phone.”

I looked at Mia.

Mia shook her head.

“She’s getting dressed,” I told Mama.

“For what?”

“The day.”

Mama sighed.

“Tell her she should come for lunch this Sunday.”

“I already told her.”

“And?”

“She said she would check.”

Mia lowered the blue dress.

“I did not say that.”

I turned away from her.

“Mama, I need to get ready.”

“Wear the navy dress,” Mama said.

“The one with the small buttons?”

“Yes.”

“It makes me look like a school principal.”

“That is why it looks responsible.”

“I’m not applying to run a school.”

“Responsible is responsible.”

I looked toward the wardrobe.

The navy dress was still hanging at the back.

“Fine,” I said. “I’ll try it.”

“And call me after the interview.”

“I will.”

“Immediately.”

“Yes, Mama.”

“Not three hours later.”

“I understand.”

“Good luck, anak.”

My mom’s voice softened when she said it.

“Thank you, Mama.”

I ended the call.

Mia was holding the navy dress now.

“She is right,” Mia admitted.

I stared at her. “You rejected everything I chose.”

“I was waiting for a better option.”

“Mama chose it.”

“And I agree with her.”

“You could have suggested it ten minutes ago.”

“I wanted you to reach the conclusion naturally.”

“You did not reach anything. Mama called.”

Mia handed me the dress.

“Details.”

The navy dress fit better than I remembered.

It reached just below my knees and had short sleeves, a plain collar, and small silver buttons down the front.

I looked professional.

I also looked like I might ask a room full of children to stop talking.

Mia stood behind me.

“Turn around,” she instructed.

I turned.

She studied the dress.

“It is acceptable.”

“Acceptable?”

“You look reliable.”

“That is good.”

“You also look like you carry emergency tissue.”

“I do carry emergency tissue.”

“Exactly.”

I added a black blazer and low heels.

The blazer was slightly tight around my arms, but I could move as long as I did not try to reach for anything above my head.

Mia adjusted the collar.

“Do not take off the blazer,” she said.

“Why?”

“There is a loose thread on the back of the dress.”

I tried to turn around.

“Where?”

“You cannot see it.”

“How long is it?”

“Not long.”

“Mia.”

“It is noticeable only if someone is staring.”

“People will stare during an interview.”

“They will look at your face.”

“What if I turn around?”

“Do not turn around dramatically.”

I closed my eyes.

“This is already going badly.”

“You have not left the apartment.”

“That is what worries me.”

I ate half a piece of bread because my stomach refused everything else.

Mia made coffee, but after two sips, I poured the rest into the sink.

“You need energy,” Mia said.

“I need my hands to stop shaking.”

“They are not shaking.”

I held one hand out.

My fingers trembled slightly.

Mia watched them.

“That is barely movement.”

“I look nervous.”

“You are nervous.”

“I don’t want them to know.”

“They already know. Nobody attends an interview because they feel relaxed.”

I packed my CV, certificates, identification card, notebook, pen, tissues, mint candy, and a small bottle of water into my bag.

Then I checked everything again.

Mia watched from the sofa.

“You have your CV,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Your phone?”

“Yes.”

“Your wallet?”

“Yes.”

“Your confidence?”

I looked at her.

“No.”

Mia picked up her bag.

“I’ll bring extra.”

We left the apartment at eight fifteen.

I had planned to leave at eight.

The first delay happened because I could not find my keys.

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The second happened because Mia insisted I change my earrings.

The third happened because I went back upstairs to check whether I had unplugged the iron.

I had.

By the time we reached the main road, the heat had already settled over the city.

People crowded the pavement. Motorcycles moved between cars. A jeepney stopped several metres away from the proper loading area, and everyone around us began walking faster.

“That one,” Mia said.

“It’s full.”

“There is space.”

“There is space for a bag.”

“Then become flexible.”

We climbed inside.

I sat near the entrance with my knees pressed together and my bag held against my chest.

Mia squeezed beside me.

An older woman across from us looked at the empty space near my shoulder.

“Miss,” the woman said, “can you move a little? Someone else can sit there.”

I looked at Mia.

Mia was sitting beside me.

“There isn’t much space,” I replied.

The woman looked again.

“There is enough for one person.”

Mia crossed her arms.

“I was here first,” she whispered.

I shifted slightly toward the window.

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Another passenger sat in the narrow space beside me.

Mia stood.

“This is disrespectful,” she said.

“I’m sorry,” I whispered.

The passenger beside me turned.

“Sorry for what?” she asked.

“Nothing,” I replied quickly.

Mia held the rail above us.

“You allowed a stranger to take my seat.”

“It’s public transport.”

“I paid.”

“You did not pay.”

“You paid for both of us.”

“No, I didn’t.”

The driver called for fares.

I passed my payment forward.

“One,” I said.

Mia stared at me.

“What?” I whispered.

“You said one.”

“One fare.”

“And what about me?”

“You never pay.”

“That does not mean I travel for free.”

I looked out the window.

“I am not discussing this here.”

A young man near the driver glanced back at me.

I lowered my voice.

Mia leaned closer.

“You are tense again.”

“Because I am going to be late.”

“We are not late.”

I checked the time.

It was eight thirty-two.

“We still need to take the train.”

“We have time.”

“You always say that before we start running.”

We reached the office building at nine thirty-eight.

I was twenty-two minutes early.

Mia acted as though this proved she had been right all morning.

The building was taller than I expected. It had glass doors, polished floors, and a security desk staffed by two guards who looked much more organised than I felt.

I stopped outside.

Mia stood beside me.

“Why are you not moving?” she asked.

“I’m preparing.”

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“For what?”

“To enter.”

“You walk through the door.”

“I know how doors work.”

“Then demonstrate.”

I took a breath.

“Do I look all right?” I asked.

Mia examined me.

“Yes.”

“Are you sure?”

“You look employed.”

“I am not employed.”

“Not with that attitude.”

I adjusted my bag.

“What if they ask about my age?”

“They are not supposed to.”

“What if they do?”

“Tell them you are experienced.”

“What if they ask why I graduated late?”

“Tell them the truth.”

“Which part?”

Mia counted on her fingers.

“You worked. You helped Mama after her surgery. You stopped studying because of money. You went back when you could.”

“That sounds like a lot.”

“It is your life.”

“What if they think I’m too old for an entry-level job?”

Mia’s expression changed.

She stepped closer.

“Then they do not deserve you,” she said.

I looked at her.

“That sounds like something people say when they know you did not get the job.”

“You have not even entered the building.”

“You said it very emotionally.”

“I was being supportive.”

“You scared me.”

Mia sighed.

“Fine. They will love you. You will receive an offer before lunch. By Friday, they will give you an office.”

“It’s a junior position.”

“Then a junior office.”

“That does not exist.”

“You are wasting time, Ana.”

She was right.

I walked inside.

At the security desk, I gave my name and showed the interview email.

The guard checked a list.

“Northline Media, twelfth floor,” he said. “Leave one ID here.”

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I handed him my card.

Mia leaned toward the desk and examined the visitor pass.

“The picture is worse than your CV picture,” she whispered.

I ignored her.

“Elevators are on the left,” the guard added.

“Thank you,” I replied.

As I walked away, Mia followed me.

“Your hair is sticking up at the back,” she said.

I stopped.

“Where?”

“Near the crown.”

I touched my hair.

“Did I fix it?”

“No.”

I touched it again.

“Now?”

“You made it worse.”

A woman standing near the elevator glanced at me.

She wore a cream blouse, black trousers, and pointed shoes that looked expensive.

Her hair was pulled into a neat ponytail. She held a slim folder against her chest.

“Interview?” she asked.

I lowered my hand.

“Yes,” I replied.

“Northline?”

“Yes.”

The woman smiled.

“Same.”

The elevator arrived, and we stepped inside.

Mia entered beside me.

The woman pressed twelve.

“I’m Jen,” she said.

“Ana.”

Jen looked at my visitor pass.

“Communications assistant?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“Me too.”

My stomach tightened again.

Jen looked younger than me. Maybe twenty-seven or twenty-eight.

She looked prepared.

I looked like I carried emergency tissue.

“Do you have experience?” Jen asked.

“A little,” I replied. “Mostly part-time and temporary work.”

“I worked in social media for three years,” Jen said. “The company closed last month.”

“I’m sorry.”

“It’s fine. It happens.”

Mia stood beside Jen and examined her clothes.

“She is overdressed,” Mia whispered.

I kept my eyes on the elevator doors.

Jen continued speaking.

“I saw the job post had more than two hundred applicants,” she said.

I looked at her. “Two hundred?”

“According to the site.”

Mia leaned closer to me.

“She is trying to scare you.”

I nodded without thinking.

Jen noticed.

“You saw it too?” she asked.

“No,” I replied. “I was just thinking.”

The elevator stopped at the seventh floor.

Two men entered.

Jen moved closer to me.

“So, did you just graduate?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“What year?”

“This year.”

Jen smiled. “Same. I finished a short postgraduate course.”

“That’s good.”

“What about you?”

“Business communication.”

Jen glanced at me again.

“Career change?”

Before I could answer, Mia spoke.

“That is a polite way of asking why you are old.”

I stared at the elevator numbers.

“Yes,” I replied to Jen. “Something like that.”

Jen nodded.

“I think it’s brave,” she said.

The answer sounded kind, but I could not tell whether she meant it kindly.

Mia could not tell either.

“She is studying you,” Mia whispered.

“Stop,” I muttered.

Jen looked at me.

“Sorry?”

“Nothing. I was reminding myself to stop overthinking.”

Jen laughed softly.

“I do that too.”

The elevator reached the twelfth floor.

The doors opened into a bright reception area with white walls and framed advertisements.

A receptionist looked up from her desk.

“Good morning,” she said. “Are you here for the communications interviews?”

“Yes,” Jen and I answered at the same time.

The receptionist handed us forms.

“Please complete these and take a seat. Someone will call you shortly.”

There were already three people waiting.

All of them looked younger than me.

One man wore a suit and tie.

Another woman had a tablet, a leather portfolio, and the calm expression of someone who had prepared answers for questions that had not yet been invented.

I chose a chair near the end of the row.

Jen sat two seats away.

Mia sat between us.

I began filling out the form.

Name.

Address.

Education.

Previous employment.

Expected salary.

I paused.

Mia leaned over my shoulder.

“Write thirty-five thousand,” she whispered.

“I cannot write that,” I whispered back.

“Why?”

“The post said twenty-two to twenty-six.”

“Then write thirty.”

“They will reject me.”

“Negotiation begins with courage.”

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“I need employment more than courage.”

The man beside me looked over.

“Did you say something?” he asked.

I smiled.

“No. Sorry.”

I wrote twenty-six thousand.

Mia shook her head.

“Coward.”

“Realist,” I whispered.

Jen leaned around Mia’s chair.

“Did you bring a portfolio?” she asked.

I looked at the folder on her lap.

“No,” I replied. “The email didn’t ask for one.”

“They didn’t ask me either,” Jen said. “I just brought samples.”

My mouth went dry.

“What kind of samples?”

“Campaign plans, social media posts, reports.”

Mia looked at Jen’s folder.

“We can steal it,” she whispered.

I stared at Mia.

“We are not stealing anything.”

The receptionist looked up.

“Excuse me?” she asked.

I lowered my head.

“I said I didn’t bring anything,” I replied.

The receptionist gave me a polite smile and returned to her computer.

Jen watched me for a moment.

“Are you all right?” she asked.

“Yes.”

“You seem nervous.”

“I am nervous.”

Jen smiled.

“Me too.”

“You don’t look nervous.”

“That is because I practised looking calm.”

I laughed.

For the first time since meeting her, Jen seemed less like a rival and more like another unemployed person wearing uncomfortable shoes.

“What did you practise?” I asked.

“My introduction. My weaknesses. Why they should hire me.”

Mia leaned back in her chair.

“See? Everyone lies about weaknesses.”

Jen continued.

“My sister asked me questions last night. She was brutal.”

“Mia practised with me,” I said.

Jen looked toward the empty chair between us.

“Your friend?”

“My housemate.”

“That’s nice.”

“It wasn’t nice,” I replied. “She said my first answer sounded like I was reading my birth certificate.”

Jen laughed.

Mia looked offended.

“It did,” Mia said.

The receptionist called the first applicant.

The man in the suit stood and followed a staff member through a glass door.

The waiting area became quiet again.

I looked down at my hands.

They had started shaking.

Mia noticed.

She rested her hand over mine.

“You are going to be fine,” she said.

“I don’t feel fine,” I whispered.

“You do not need to feel confident. You only need to answer the questions.”

“What if my mind goes blank?”

“I will be there.”

“You cannot answer for me.”

“I know.”

Mia squeezed my hand.

“But I can remind you that you know more than you think.”

I took a slow breath.

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Across the room, Jen was reviewing her notes.

The other applicants were checking their phones.

No one looked at Mia.

No one spoke to her.

But she was beside me.

That was enough.

A few minutes later, the glass door opened.

A woman in a grey blazer stepped into the waiting area.

“Ana Lim?” she called.

My stomach dropped.

I stood.

Mia stood with me.

“That’s me,” I said.

The woman smiled.

“Good morning. I’m Tess from human resources. Please come with me.”

I picked up my bag and followed her toward the interview room.

Mia walked beside me.

“Shoulders back,” she whispered.

I straightened.

“Walk slowly.”

I slowed down.

“Not that slowly.”

I increased my pace.

Tess glanced back at me.

“Everything okay?” she asked.

“Yes,” I replied. “I’m just trying not to walk too fast.”

Tess smiled.

“You’re fine.”

Mia leaned closer.

“She likes you already.”

“She said two words,” I whispered.

Tess stopped near the door.

“Sorry?” she asked.

I smiled.

“I said thank you.”

Tess opened the door.

Three people were waiting inside.

For one second, every answer I had practised disappeared.

Mia stood beside me.

“Breathe,” she said quietly.

I did.

Then I entered the room.